



of one and two in the knockout matches. But, as it often happens in cricket, the law of averages caught up with them, and in the final, unfortunately for Kerala. Something similar happened to Vidarbha's leading scorer, Yash Rathod. He had come into the match having made 933 runs, but he failed in both innings. He, however, finished as the season's highest scorer (960 runs).

The tournament's highest wicket-taker is also from Vidarbha. Harsh Dubey actually set a new record for a Ranji season, with 69 wickets. The 22-year-old is a talented left-arm spinner who can also bat. He looks like a bright prospect.

Danish Malewar, the player of the final, is a year younger. While making 153 and 73, he displayed temperament, technique and the ability to play some pleasing shots on the leg side, especially on the back foot. And this was his maiden season in the Ranji Trophy.

Dazzling duo: Kerala's Mohammed Azharuddeen (635 runs in 10 matches) and Salman Nizar (628 in nine matches) were the standout performers for their team during this Ranji Trophy campaign. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Surely, Vidarbha knows how to blood its young players at the right time. And former India pacer Prashant Vaidya has shown how setting up an academy and working at the grassroots can slowly turn a team with no tradition into a champion side.

"It is great to see all our hard work paying off," Vaidya, who was once regarded as the fastest bowler in India, told *Sportstar*. "When I started out, Vidarbha wasn't a strong side at all. In fact, some cricketers were not even aware that Vidarbha had a Ranji Trophy team."

Fairy tales like this should inspire other teams, including Kerala.

Top five wicket-takers (2025)



Harsh Dubey (Vidarbha)

69 wickets in 10 matches (BB: 6/36, Avg: 16.98)

Auqib Nabi (Jammu & Kashmir)

44 wickets in 8 matches (BB: 6/53, Avg: 13.93)

Shams Mulani (Mumbai)

44 wickets in 9 matches (BB: 6/85, Avg: 23.52)

Dharmendrasinh Jadeja (Saurashtra)

40 wickets in 8 matches (BB: 6/51, Avg: 20.85)

Jalaj Saxena (Kerala)

40 wickets in 10 matches (BB: 6/41, Avg: 22.55)